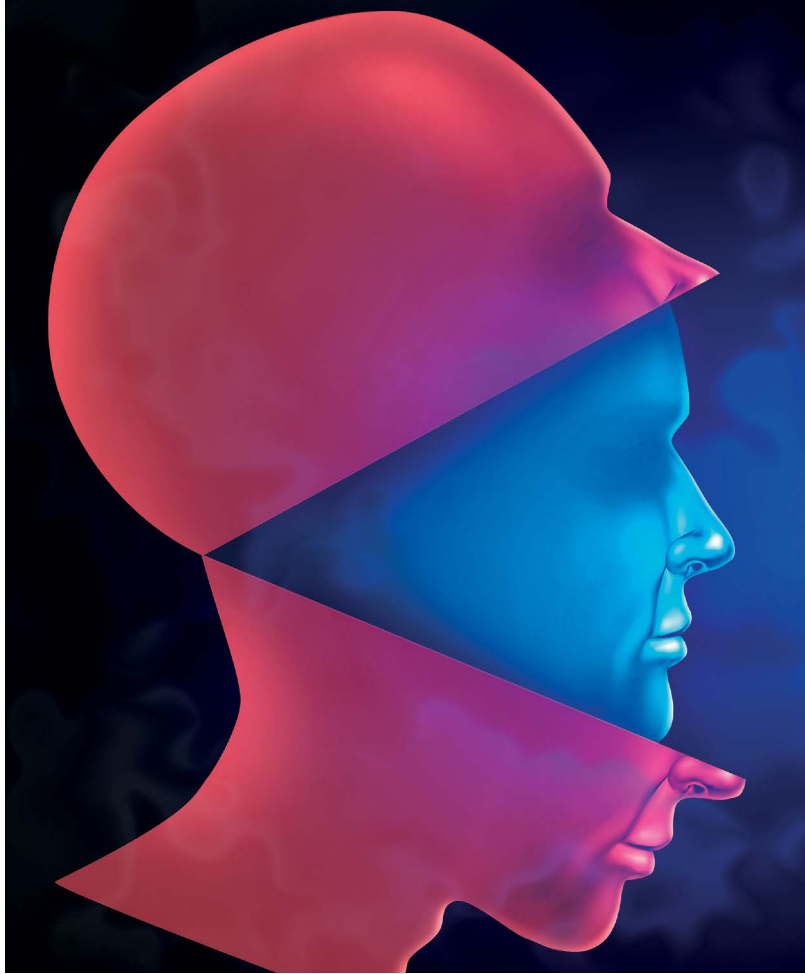




A Real Problem

The recent instances of viral deepfake videos have spurred the government into action

BY DANNY CYRIL DCRUZE

► **DEEPFAKE VIDEOS OF** many prominent personalities have been doing the rounds on social media platforms lately. Even Prime Minister Narendra Modi recently cautioned against the phenomenon, citing a deepfake video of him doing garba that he had seen recently.

Developed using artificial intelligence and machine learning algorithms, deepfakes are manipulated images, sounds and voices, generated to create realistic but fake representations of people, events, or scenarios. While some deepfakes are harmless or even entertaining, others can have serious negative consequences.

Jiten Jain, Director at cybersecurity firm Voyager Infosec, says not every deepfake can be classified as disinformation if it is generated with the consent of the people involved. He also points out the challenges in verifying the authenticity

of these videos, especially when it comes to sensitive issues such as disseminating news. He cites the insufficient regulations around using the tech as the cause. “The existing rules... are not sufficient. We need a comprehensive overhaul of the IT law, where there are clear rules about who can use this, for what purpose it can be used, should it be licensed, what is the responsibility of the person generating the video, and the person who’s getting the video generated. And what is the responsibility of the platform to

DEEPFAKES OFFER CREATIVE POSSIBILITIES, BUT THEY ALSO JEOPARDISE INFORMATION INTEGRITY

take it down; who’s responsible to flag it?” Jain says.

It is in this context that IT minister Ashwini Vaishnaw recently said the government plans to discuss the matter with social media platforms. “We’ll make sure that platforms make adequate efforts for preventing it (deepfakes), and cleaning up their system,” he said.

Vinod Singh, CTO of software company Concurrus, agrees that they pose a serious threat, but offers a word of caution. “While offering creative possibilities, they jeopardise information integrity and trust. Striking a balance between harnessing its potential and mitigating risks is crucial for its responsible evolution,” he says, adding that tech firms have a responsibility towards preventing its misuse. He says, “It is up to us to decide how we want to use it and how we want to regulate it. We need to act fast, before it is too late”. **BT**

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